Multiple Recovery Paths in a Lesioned Transformer

Internal Rerouting and Readout Remapping

Lorenzo Cannata | Uri Hasson

BlackboxNLP 2026 | Poster #192

Motivation

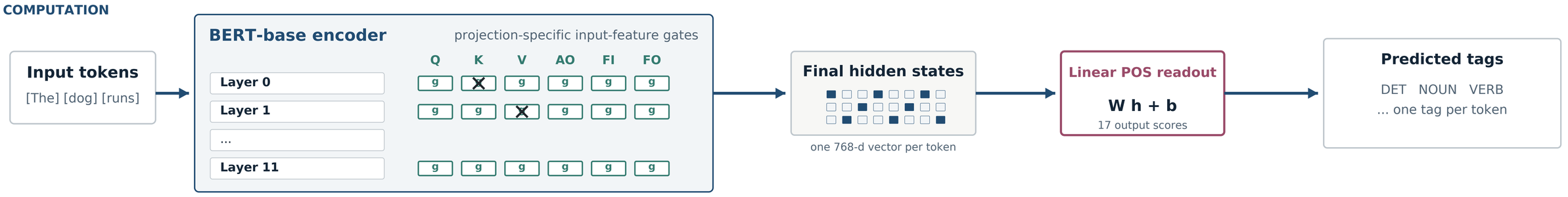
Using BERT as a frozen encoder and a linear part-of-speech (POS) readout as a task classifier, we first use gate masking to learn a sparse core subnetwork sufficient for POS classification. We then ablate this subnetwork to produce a large drop in performance. Our main question is whether performance can recover by adapting the surviving projection-specific gates, retraining the linear POS readout, or both.

CENTRAL FINDING

Recovery can use internal rerouting or readout retraining; among fixed-weight routes, combining both recovers most without necessarily restoring the original representation.

Experimental framework

COMPUTATION



EXPERIMENTAL PROGRESSION

A Learn the task-sufficient core

Train projection-specific hard-concrete gates and the linear POS readout while pretrained encoder weights remain fixed.

Gates	TRAIN
Readout	TRAIN
Encoder weights	FIXED

The sparse configuration reaches 94.98% primary-run POS accuracy.

B Apply a permanent lesion

Gates used by the task-sufficient core are permanently disabled. Their effective values are zero and gradients are blocked.

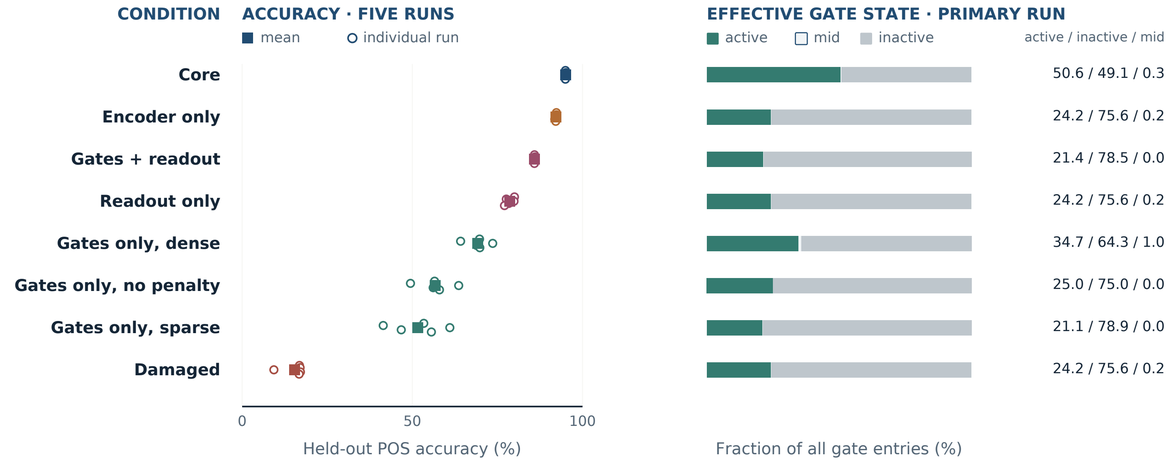
C Recovery trainability

Condition	Gates	Readout	Encoder	Lesion
Gates only	TRAIN	FIXED	FIXED	OFF
Readout only	FIXED	TRAIN	FIXED	OFF
Gates + readout	TRAIN	TRAIN	FIXED	OFF
Encoder only	FIXED	FIXED	TRAIN	OFF

SETUP	bert-base-uncased | UD English-EWT | 17 POS tags | 25,147 development tokens
LESION	74 grouped Q/K/V input-coordinate masks; 5 attention-output, 9 FFN-intermediate, and 4 FFN-output projection-mask tensors; 37,248 entries clamped to -12 and gradient-blocked

Performance and gate state

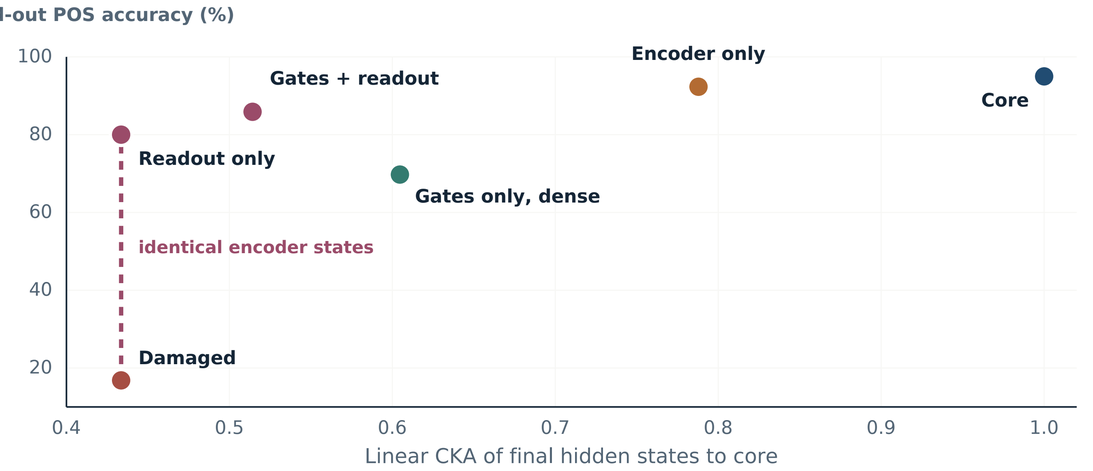
Five-run accuracy · primary-run gates



Circles show individual runs; squares show their means. The bars show effective gate states at the primary-run endpoint: active p > 0.99, inactive p < 0.01, and intermediate otherwise. Lesioned entries stay fixed at -12.

Performance vs. encoder geometry

Primary run

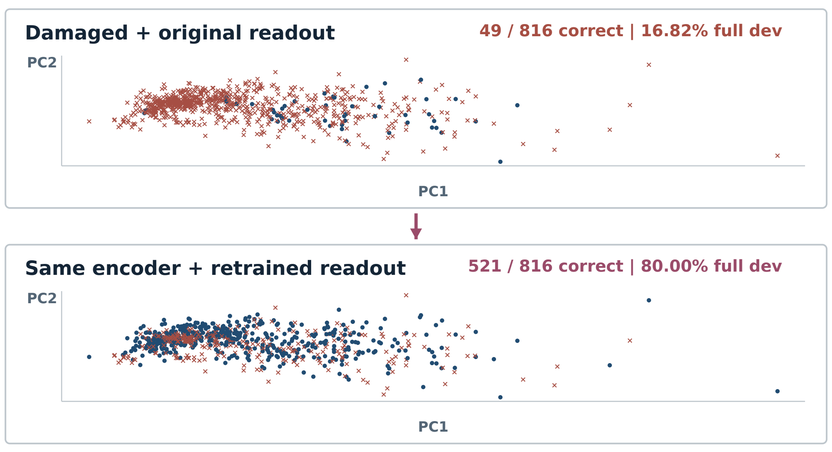


Readout-only retraining leaves the damaged encoder representation unchanged. Accuracy rises from 16.82% to 80.00%, while linear CKA to the pre-lesion core remains 0.43.

Encoder and readout geometry change differently across recovery paths

Readout-only recovery

Same encoder states for 816 tokens; only the linear readout changes

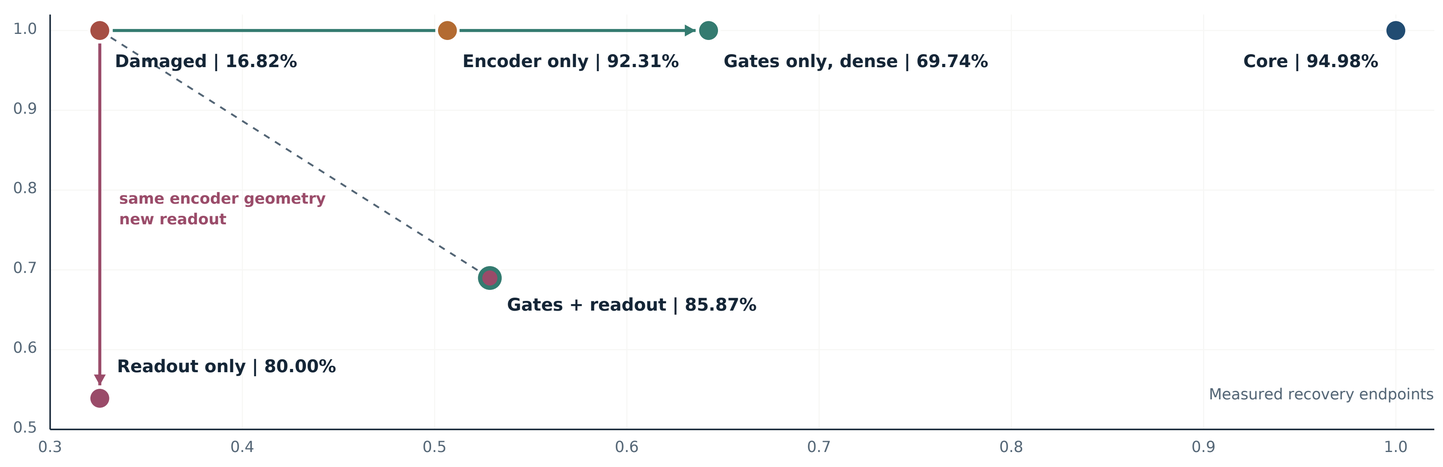


Each token stays at the same PC1-PC2 coordinate in both panels. This is a 2D view of the encoder states; POS predictions use all 768 dimensions.

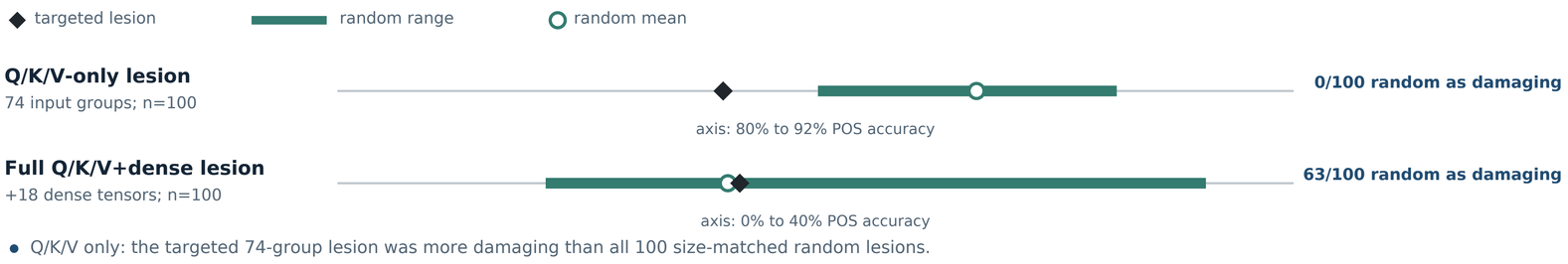
POS-centroid geometry vs. readout-weight geometry

x: encoder POS-centroid RDM | y: classifier-weight RDM | primary run

Spearman similarity of readout-weight RDM to core



Robustness and controls



- Q/K/V only: the targeted 74-group lesion was more damaging than all 100 size-matched random lesions.
- Full lesion: with the same Q/K/V and dense counts chosen at random, 63/100 lesions were at least as damaging.

Conclusions

Performance can recover without relearning the underlying transformations.

The extent to which the original geometry is recovered depends on the degrees of freedom of the recovery protocol.

Circuit necessity is conditional on the permitted rerouting strategy. A component may be necessary under the original fixed routing and readout, but cease to be so when the readout can be retrained or surviving transformations can be reselected.

LIMITATIONS

Our evaluations were based on a single task and a single backbone model.

EXPLORE THE EXPERIMENT

mechint25.github.io

Methods: Louizos et al. (2018); Cao et al. (2021). Data: Universal Dependencies English-EWT.